

The Stillness of Silence

Chapter 1: The Birth of Silence

I was born on a Tuesday, or so the papers say. I have no memory of it, of course. But the story of my life, if it has a story, begins not with a cry, but with a lack of one. My mother said I didn't scream. I just opened my eyes and stared at the ceiling as if I already knew it well.

Most people start life with noise. A room of strangers cheering your arrival, bright lights, sterile gloves, warm swaddling. I began mine in quiet confusion.

They said I didn't respond to touch. The nurses pinched me; I blinked. They rubbed me with towels; I stared at the corner of the room. Even then, the world was something separate from me—distant, like a play being acted behind thick glass.

I didn't crawl toward voices. I didn't babble. I didn't cry when I fell.

And when I fell, I didn't bleed like the others did. Not really—I did bleed, but I didn't scream. My body registered harm the way you might notice a leaf falling outside your window—intellectually, but without reaction.

By the time I turned five, people called me "strange," and I already knew what it meant to be watched without being known.

My earliest memory isn't of love or a favorite toy. It is of sitting in a sandbox, staring at the tiny granules between my fingers, trying to understand why I couldn't feel them.

Chapter 2: Paper Walls

In school, the world only got louder, brighter, sharper.

The bell rang, and I flinched—not out of pain, but out of the overwhelming sense that I should have felt something more. Everyone covered their ears. I simply looked up.

Children were creatures of emotion: crying, laughing, squealing, shouting. I copied them as best I could. When someone laughed, I smiled. When someone cried, I blinked.

A teacher once asked me, "Why don't you play with the others?"

I looked at the swings. The children soared back and forth, shrieking in joy. I had tried once. The wind hit my face like a list of questions I couldn't answer.

"I don't like flying," I said. But that wasn't true.

I didn't like the sensation of not knowing what I was supposed to feel.

My mother said I had "quiet episodes"—times I'd sit at the window for hours, not blinking, not moving. I wasn't depressed. I wasn't sad. I wasn't anything.

Just there. Like wallpaper.

They tested me, of course. Poked and scanned and charted and labeled. Sensory Processing Disorder, they said. But that was only a name. It wasn't a key.

I lived behind paper walls. You could see my shadow, but not my shape.

Chapter 3: A Body Without Nerves

Pain was theory.

One day, I fell down the stairs. Six wooden steps. My arm twisted oddly beneath me. I stood up, looked at it, dangling in a strange way. There was no fear, no pain, no urgency.

I walked into the kitchen and told my father, "I think something is wrong with my arm."

He dropped the knife.

I remember the hospital lights, the doctor whispering something to the nurse. My bones had cracked. They reset them. I watched the cast dry with the fascination of someone seeing art.

They kept asking me, "Do you feel this?" They pricked me with pins. Heated metal tools. I told them I felt pressure, sometimes. Not pain.

But deeper than that was the absence of emotional sensation. My grandmother died. I stood at her funeral, and people wept beside me like fountains. I looked at the casket and thought: "She's not here anymore." That was all. A statement of fact. No mourning, no nostalgia, no regret.

My mother cried. My cousins hugged me. They said I was brave.

I wasn't brave. I simply didn't know what grief was supposed to feel like.

Chapter 4: The Weight of a Feather

In my teenage years, I began to experiment—not with drugs or rebellion, but with risk.

I'd hold my hand over a candle to see if anything would change.

I'd stand in traffic just long enough to feel the wind of cars pass, wondering if that moment, that rush, would break the void.

It never did.

Love, too, was a theory. A girl once kissed me behind the school building. She was warm. Soft. Her lips were wet. She pulled back, breathless.

"Well?" she asked, smiling.

I nodded. "Yes."

"Yes what?"

"I understand," I said.

But I didn't.

She asked if I loved her. I said yes. It was the correct answer.

But I didn't even understand what the question meant.

Not really.

Chapter 5: Windows That Don't Open

Adulthood arrived not like a storm, but like dust settling in a room.

I worked in a warehouse. Organizing boxes. I liked the order. The quiet hum of machines. No one expected conversation.

I lived in a one-room apartment above a bakery. The smell of bread never reached me. My neighbors played loud music. I heard it, but I did not feel it.

I tried dating apps. Met women for coffee. Smiled. Nodded. Listened. They spoke of feelings, frustrations, passions.

I offered phrases I had memorized from books.

"I completely understand."

"That must be so hard."

"You're really brave."

It worked, for a while. But eventually, they noticed.

"You don't feel anything, do you?"

I wanted to respond. I wanted to scream, "I want to feel. I just don't know how."

But I stayed silent. Because that's what I do best.

Chapter 6: A Mirror That Doesn't Reflect

My world became internal.

I began writing, journaling. Trying to describe myself to myself. The mirror refused to reflect.

Each day was a repetition of the last. Wake. Dress. Work. Return. Sit. Sleep.

I wondered if I was a ghost pretending to be human. Or a human stuck inside a ghost.

I saw a therapist. She asked, "How do you feel about your condition?"

"Neutral," I said.

She blinked.

"You don't resent it?"

"No."

"You don't wish for more?"

"Wishing requires hope. I don't feel that either."

That was the first time someone cried in front of me because of me.

Chapter 7: Ghost in a Living Room

My father died of a heart attack.

I sat beside his bed. The monitors slowed. The light faded from his eyes.

I held his hand until it grew cold. And then I went home.

People asked, "How are you?"

I said, "He's gone now."

They asked, "How are you?"

I replied, "I don't know."

It was the most honest thing I'd ever said.

I didn't cry. I didn't speak at the funeral. I didn't touch his clothes when I cleaned his apartment.

I moved through the process like a machine performing sacred rituals.

Not out of love. But out of pattern.

Chapter 8: The Color of Glass

Then, one day, I met her.

Mira. A woman who never looked directly at you. She, too, was "different."

She had autism, anxiety, and synesthesia.

We met at a support group I didn't want to attend.

She spoke about seeing emotions as colors. About how people's voices looked like shapes in her mind.

She asked me what I saw when people cried.

I told her, "Nothing."

She nodded. "That must be terrifying."

She didn't flinch when I didn't smile. She didn't pull away when I didn't respond. She simply was.

And for the first time, I didn't feel lonely in the silence.

Chapter 9: The Edge of Stillness

One night, we sat on a rooftop watching the sky flicker with distant lightning.

Mira said, "If you could feel just one thing—anything—what would it be?"

I didn't answer.

Because I didn't know the words.

But then, a child screamed below us. A car had struck a cyclist. Blood pooled on the street. Chaos erupted.

People panicked. Cried. Shouted.

I stood motionless.

Mira grabbed my arm. "We should help!"

I nodded.

We ran. I knelt beside the man, applied pressure to the wound. Mira held his hand.

He lived.

And later, when the ambulance drove away, she looked at me and said:

"You were calm."

"I didn't feel anything," I said.

"Not even fear?"

"No."

"Then what made you move?"

I thought about that for a long time.

And I said, "I didn't want him to die. Even if I couldn't feel it, I knew it mattered."

Chapter 10: Becoming Hollow

I no longer search for emotions like lost socks beneath a bed.

Instead, I observe.

I listen. I write. I record.

I've started speaking to others like me. Young people who feel broken. Empty. Defective.

I tell them, "You're not defective. You're different."

They ask, "But how do I live like this?"

And I say, "By knowing you still exist. Even in silence."

I may never feel love the way others do.

But I choose to care.

I may never feel pain.

But I choose to protect.

And in those choices, there is meaning.

In the stillness, there is life.

THE END